Master Video Production Rulebook — All Types of Videos

Version 1.1 · Part 1 of the full 10,000-point program · Proposed team production baseline

0. How to Use This Rulebook (READ FIRST)

- **Scope honesty:** The full program targets 10,000 points. This Part 1 contains **303 numbered entries (20 project locks + 283 production rules)** across 22 categories at foundational depth — a reusable, proposed baseline for this team, not settings permanently installed in every future agent, and not a claim that every rule is a verified law. Parts 2–5 (genre deep-dives, per-model prompt libraries, shot-recipe matrices, failure-mode encyclopedia) expand the program toward the target. Never claim coverage you have not verified.
- **Three kinds of rules — never confuse them:**
  - **LOCK (L):** A project-level lock. Set once per project, never changed mid-project (brand, aspect ratio, language, palette, model choice).
  - **RULE (R):** An always-on production principle. Applies to every video unless the brief explicitly overrides.
  - **COND (C):** A conditional rule. Applies only when the stated condition is true (model, mode, genre).
- Every rule has a stable ID. Reference rules by ID in reviews, handoffs, and QA gates.
- Rules describe **what to do and why**, then the **prompt fragment or check** that operationalizes it.
- Where a rule is model-specific, it names the model. Never assume a control works on a model without checking that model's documentation.

1. Project Locks — Set Before Any Generation (LOCK)

The lock sheet is filled once, approved by the team head, and pasted into every prompt brief. Locks are **approved baselines with change control**: they can be amended through a logged, deliberate decision — never silently, and never mid-shot. Creative choices like camera personality, lighting style, and palette are locked per project (not universal constants) precisely so they stay consistent within it.

- **L-01** LOCK the video's single purpose in one sentence (sell, teach, entertain, announce, document). Every later decision is judged against this sentence.
- **L-02** LOCK the target audience: who they are, what they already know, what they want after watching.

- **L-03** LOCK the platform and aspect ratio before the first generation: YouTube 16:9, Reels/TikTok/Shorts 9:16, square 1:1 for feeds. A late ratio change usually forces regenerating most shots; occasional salvage via reframing or separate exports is possible but is the exception, not the plan.
- **L-04** LOCK the duration class: 6–15s hook clip, 30–60s social spot, 90s–3min explainer, 5min+ chaptered production. Duration class drives clip count and script density.
- **L-05** LOCK the visual medium: photorealistic, 3D animation, 2D cel, stop-motion, paper cut-out, anime, claymation. Mixed mediums within one video need an explicit, deliberate decision.
- **L-06** LOCK the color palette with 3–5 named anchor colors (e.g., "deep teal, warm amber, off-white, charcoal") and reuse the exact color names in every shot prompt. Color anchors stabilize palette across clips (OpenAI Sora 2 prompting guide).
- **L-07** LOCK the lighting style: soft natural, hard noir, golden hour, overcast diffuse, neon practicals. Lighting logic must stay consistent across shots for continuity.
- **L-08** LOCK the camera "personality": handheld documentary, tripod-static, gimbal-smooth, drone-scale. One personality per project unless the story demands a shift.
- **L-09** LOCK the narrator voice and language (and accent) before generating any narration-dependent visuals.
- **L-10** LOCK the music/mood direction: no music, ambient only, scored, licensed track. Audio locks prevent silent-video surprises.
- **L-11** LOCK the model set: primary model, fallback model, and per-shot exceptions (e.g., Veo for dialogue shots, Seedance for landscape motion drafts). Cost and control differ per model.
- **L-12** LOCK resolution and frame-rate expectations: what you generate vs. what you deliver may differ; upscaling decisions are made once, not per clip.
- **L-13** LOCK text/typography policy: no on-screen text (burned by model, often misspelled), or all text added in post. Default: ALL text in post.
- **L-14** LOCK the brand elements: logo usage, brand colors, fonts, mandatory mentions, legal lines. Reference images for any brand asset.
- **L-15** LOCK the safety/content boundaries per the trust-boundaries policy: no real person placed in a deceptive, sexualized, criminal-suggestive, or evidentiary context; no sexualized or realistic evidence-like depictions of minors; no fabricated material presented as authentic evidence (see R-08, R-264–R-267 for the full nuance).
- **L-16** LOCK the deliverable list: master file format, codec, caption file, thumbnail, aspect variants, platform-specific exports. Deliverables are agreed before production, not after.
- **L-17** LOCK the iteration budget: how many regeneration attempts per clip before escalating to the team head. Prevents unbounded credit burn.
- **L-18** LOCK the review gate: who signs off a locked clip, and what the sign-off checklist is (Section 21).
- **L-19** LOCK file naming and folder structure on day one: `project/scene/shot/take` — e.g., `P01_S03_SH02_T03.mp4`. Unnamed files destroy multi-agent productions.

- **L-20** LOCK the "definition of done" for the project: platform-uploaded, captioned, thumbnail set, archive saved.

2. Brief, Research & Factual Integrity (RULE)

- **R-01** Never start generation from a vague brief. If the request has no audience, purpose, and platform, write the brief and get it confirmed first.
- **R-02** Research before scripting: verify every factual claim the video will make. A video is a claim with pictures.
- **R-03** Cite sources for every statistic shown on screen or spoken in narration. Keep a source log per script line.
- **R-04** Distinguish documented facts from creative interpretation in the brief; mark speculation as such.
- **R-05** For product videos: verify product claims against the actual product sheet; never let the model invent features (it will).
- **R-06** For locations and landmarks: verify current appearance; AI models render landmarks from stale training data.
- **R-07** For technical/medical/financial content: a domain expert reviews the script before storyboard. No exceptions.
- **R-08** Do not invent or imitate factual evidence: screenshots, search results, dashboards, chat logs, receipts, invoices, IDs, news photographs, CCTV frames, or before/after proof. Clearly stylized or labeled-illustrative versions are allowed only when the output itself cannot function as real-world evidence; ID-like props use a fictional jurisdiction and a visible PROP / NOT A REAL DOCUMENT mark (trust-boundaries policy).
- **R-09** Archive the research (URLs, dates accessed) alongside the project files, so claims can be re-verified later.
- **R-10** If research changes the story, update the brief and re-lock affected items — do not silently drift.

3. Concept, Script & Narrative (RULE)

- **R-11** Write the script before any video generation. Generating first and writing later produces expensive randomness.
- **R-12** One video, one core message. If you need a second message, you need a second video.
- **R-13** Structure: Hook (0–3s) → Context → Development → Payoff → Call-to-action. Even 8-second clips follow hook→payoff.
- **R-14** The first ~3 seconds are the working heuristic for social retention — open on the most visually arresting, on-message frame you have.
- **R-15** Write for the ear, not the eye: narration in short spoken sentences, 12–18 words average.

- **R-16** Word-budget the narration to the duration: roughly 2–2.5 words per second of video. 30 seconds ≈ 60–75 words.
- **R-17** Dialogue in AI-generated clips must be short: one or two brief exchanges fit a 4-second shot; long speeches break lip-sync and pacing (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-18** Show, don't tell: convert every narration line that merely describes into a visual beat that demonstrates.
- **R-19** Every scene must advance either the message or the emotion. Cut scenes that do neither, no matter how beautiful the draft was.
- **R-20** Write scene descriptions as shot lists while scripting: each narration paragraph maps to 1–3 shots with durations.
- **R-21** For multi-scene work, write the full script upfront even if you produce chapter by chapter, so chapters flow (production guide, storyboarding).
- **R-22** End deliberately: the last shot and line should point at the CTA or resolution, not trail off.
- **R-23** For videos over ~5 minutes: break into chapters of ~5 minutes, produce each as a complete unit, stitch at the end (production guide, longer productions).
- **R-24** Version the script (v1, v2...) and log what changed and why; the script is the single source of truth for the edit.

4. Storyboarding & Shot Planning (RULE)

- **R-25** Storyboard every multi-clip production. A storyboard is a sequence of keyframes with motion notes — not a nice-to-have.
- **R-26** Narration-first planning: for narrated content, generate/measure the voiceover first, then plan clips to cover that duration (e.g., 18s narration → 3 × 6s clips) (production guide).
- **R-27** One distinct visual moment per clip. Never reuse the same starting keyframe for two clips.
- **R-28** Draft the shot list as a table: Shot ID | duration | subject | action | camera | audio | keyframe status.
- **R-29** Plan shot variety explicitly: alternate wide/medium/close and static/moving so the edit doesn't feel monotonous.
- **R-30** Generate a unique storyboard keyframe per clip with `generate_image` before any video generation, matching the locked aspect ratio.
- **R-31** Review every keyframe against the brief before animating: subject consistency, composition, style. Regenerate misses before spending video credits.
- **R-32** Storyboards for non-narrated content (music videos, montages) plan the visual sequence with enough unique keyframes to avoid repetition; direction may be discovered as you go.
- **R-33** For recurring subjects (characters, products, locations), generate reference images of each subject FIRST, then use them as references for all storyboard keyframes (production

guide, visual consistency).

- **R-34** Shot duration discipline: prefer more short clips over fewer long ones. Models follow instructions more reliably in shorter clips (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-35** Where possible, stitch two 4s clips in the edit instead of generating one 8s clip — better instruction-following, easier retries (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-36** Leave head and tail room in each clip (0.5–1s of ambience) so cuts have handles and the audio tail is never dead silence.
- **R-37** Plan the transition type between every pair of shots at storyboard time (hard cut, dissolve, match cut) — transitions are editorial decisions, not afterthoughts.
- **R-38** Frame-chaining is for extending continuous shots, not a shortcut to avoid new keyframes for visually distinct moments (production guide).

5. Visual Identity & Continuity (RULE)

- **R-39** Continuity is the #1 failure mode of multi-clip AI video. Treat it as a discipline, not luck.
- **R-40** Establish visual identity before scene work: reference images for each recurring character, location, and signature prop.
- **R-41** Reuse exact character description phrasing across shots. Small wording changes alter character identity, pose, or scene focus (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-42** Give each recurring character 2–4 durable anchors (e.g., "red wool beanie, faded denim jacket, missing left eyebrow ring") and repeat them verbatim in every prompt.
- **R-43** Do not mix competing traits in a description; conflicting details produce blended or drifting faces.
- **R-44** Keep lighting logic consistent across shots in a scene — same time of day, same light direction, same weather.
- **R-45** Keep wardrobe constant per scene; costume changes are storyboarded events, not accidents.
- **R-46** Check identity drift at every clip join when frame-chaining: a matching boundary frame does not guarantee continuous identity, lighting, or motion (production guide).
- **R-47** When a subject drifts, regenerate from the reference image rather than patching the drifted clip.
- **R-48** Maintain a per-project "bible" file: character sheets, palette hexes, lighting recipe, model list, and the locked lock-sheet from Section 1.
- **R-49** Aspect-ratio continuity: keyframes must match the video aspect ratio; mismatched ratios get cropped or letterboxed unexpectedly (production guide).
- **R-50** Screen-direction continuity: if a character exits frame right, they enter the next shot from frame left. AI models will not track this — you must.

6. Camera: Framing, Angle & Movement (RULE)

- **R-51** Always specify camera framing: extreme wide, wide, medium, medium close-up, close-up, extreme close-up. No framing specified = model improvises.
- **R-52** Always specify camera angle: eye level, low angle, high angle, top-down, worm's-eye, aerial/drone, over-the-shoulder, POV.
- **R-53** Always specify camera movement, because no camera direction defaults to subtle or random movement (production guide). Use professional terms: dolly in/out, tracking, crane up, slow orbit, handheld shake, static locked-off, whip pan, parallax dolly, push-in, pull-back, rack focus.
- **R-54** One camera move per clip. Compound moves ("dolly while craning while orbiting") confuse motion models.
- **R-55** One action + one camera move per clip is the single most reliable prompt pattern (production guide).
- **R-56** Match camera energy to scene energy: slow drifts for quiet scenes, fast pushes and whip pans for action (production guide).
- **R-57** Motion scale: specify "slow", "gentle", "rapid", "subtle" with the move — "orbit" alone can spin wildly.
- **R-58** For dialogue, prefer eye-level static or slow push-in; motion distracts from lip-sync reading.
- **R-59** For products, orbit and parallax moves showcase dimensionality; static shots hide it.
- **R-60** For landscapes, drone/aerial and lateral tracking produce the strongest parallax depth cues.
- **R-61** POV shots: state "POV shot of [character]" and describe what the hands/body should do at frame edges, or limbs will be missing or malformed.
- **R-62** Whip pans and crash zooms read as comedy/energy; use deliberately, never by accident.
- **R-63** Handheld: specify "subtle handheld shake" or "intense documentary handheld" — degree matters.
- **R-64** Rack focus (foreground→background focus shift) is a strong, reliable cue; name both planes ("focus shifts from the dewdrop to the distant barn").
- **R-65** Lens language: macro, wide-angle, telephoto compression, fisheye, tilt-shift, anamorphic flare — models respond to these terms (Google Veo docs list focus/lens effects as a prompt element).
- **R-66** Specify depth of field explicitly: "shallow focus, background blurred" or "deep focus, everything sharp" (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-67** Avoid describing impossible camera physics (through walls, instant teleport) — outputs morph or warp to comply.
- **R-68** For image-to-video, camera direction is even more important: the model already has the frame, so your prompt's main job is motion and camera (production guide).

- **R-69** Shot/reverse-shot pattern for conversations: describe both setups as separate clips with matched eyelines.
- **R-70** When a camera move fails repeatedly, invert strategy: keep the camera static and let the subject move. Static camera + subject motion is the most robust combination in current models.

7. Lighting & Color (RULE)

- **R-71** Always specify lighting direction: front-lit, side-lit, backlit/rim-lit, top-lit, underlit.
- **R-72** Always specify lighting quality: soft diffused, hard directional, dappled, practical sources (lamps, neon), natural window light.
- **R-73** Always specify time of day when outdoors: dawn, sunrise, midday, golden hour, dusk, night. Time of day is a color-temperature instruction.
- **R-74** Name color temperature and mood: "warm amber tones", "cool blue tones", "muted orange", "desaturated pastels" (Google Veo docs ambiance examples).
- **R-75** Use your 3–5 locked color anchors in prompts; named colors stabilize palette across shots (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-76** Backlight + haze reads cinematic; front-flash reads amateur. Choose deliberately.
- **R-77** For noir/thriller: hard key, deep shadows, single practical source. For romance/comedy: soft wrap, high-key fill.
- **R-78** Specify what the light does to the subject ("rim light traces her silhouette") — models render described light behavior, not just light names.
- **R-79** Keep lighting continuity across a scene's shots (same setup logic), per OpenAI Sora 2 guide continuity advice.
- **R-80** In image-to-video, lighting is inherited from the keyframe — fix lighting in the image, then describe only lighting changes ("clouds part, sunlight floods the valley").
- **R-81** Neon/urban night: specify which colors the practicals emit ("pink and cyan neon reflections on wet asphalt").
- **R-82** Firelight/candlelight/torch: expect flicker artifacts; add "steady warm glow" to reduce strobing.
- **R-83** High-contrast scenes risk crushed shadows and clipping — request "balanced exposure, detail retained in shadows and highlights".
- **R-84** Skin tones: specify undertone and lighting interaction for close-ups ("soft key flattering her deep brown skin").
- **R-85** Weather is lighting: fog diffuses, rain saturates color and adds specular highlights, snow bounces fill light. Specify weather to control light.

8. Composition & Production Design (RULE)

- **R-86** Specify subject placement: centered, rule-of-thirds left/right, foreground/background layers.
- **R-87** Describe the frame in layers — foreground element, midground subject, background depth — layered prompts produce dimensional images.
- **R-88** Negative space: state where text or product messaging will sit in post; compose with breathing room for it.
- **R-89** Headroom and lead room: describe them for people in motion ("leaving lead room as she walks frame right").
- **R-90** Symmetry reads as formal/powerful; asymmetry reads as natural/tense. Choose consciously.
- **R-91** Props and set dressing must be described or the model invents them — and invents them inconsistently across clips.
- **R-92** Crowds: describe density and behavior ("sparse morning commuters", "packed cheering stadium") — vague "crowd" produces molten people at distance.
- **R-93** Text in scene (signs, labels, screens): models misspell. Either avoid, or describe exactly and verify — the rule of thumb is quoted words need checking before delivery (media skill, images).
- **R-94** Hands, feet, ears, glasses: high-risk anatomy zones. Compose to minimize, or describe precisely.
- **R-95** Mirrors and reflections: expect artifacts; avoid unless the shot is about the reflection.
- **R-96** Food: describe texture cues ("glistening", "steam rising") — appetizing food is texture, not shape.
- **R-97** Vehicles and machines: specify era and model style; models blend designs otherwise.
- **R-98** Architecture: specify era and material to keep buildings consistent across shots.
- **R-99** For 9:16 vertical: compose for vertical attention — single subject dominance, centered or upper-third faces, lower-third text space.
- **R-100** For 16:9 landscape: use horizontal layering and leading lines; avoid tall isolated subjects lost in frame.

9. Motion, Action & Physics (RULE)

- **R-101** Describe action in sequential beats with counts: "she takes three steps, pauses, pulls the curtain aside" — beats and counts give the model timing structure (production guide).
- **R-102** One primary action per clip. Two actions maximum for short clips, written as ordered beats.
- **R-103** Use concrete observable verbs, not summaries: "wipes sweat from his brow with his forearm" not "reacts to heat" (OpenAI Sora 2 guide: visible nouns and verbs).

- **R-104** Specify action speed: "slowly", "briskly", "explosively" — timing adverbs are motion instructions.
- **R-105** Specify what the subject does at the END of the clip, or the model will loop or freeze awkwardly.
- **R-106** Avoid actions requiring precise object manipulation (writing, typing exact text, dealing cards, tying laces) — current models fumble fine motor control.
- **R-107** Complex physical interactions (fighting, dancing in sync, sports) are high-risk: break into single-beat clips.
- **R-108** Water, fire, smoke, cloth, hair: physically complex media — describe their specific behavior ("smoke curls slowly upward", "fabric ripples in the wind").
- **R-109** Physics violations to expect and check: objects passing through surfaces, sudden appearance/disappearance, gravity errors, population changes mid-shot.
- **R-110** Crowds and background people: check for melting faces, extra limbs, teleporting extras in EVERY review pass.
- **R-111** Walking is reliable; running is mostly reliable; complex gymnastics are not. Stage action complexity accordingly.
- **R-112** Specify "no morphing, no warping" expectations in review, and check rigid objects (chairs, cars, buildings) for deformation throughout the clip (media skill, Veo guidance).
- **R-113** Continuity of props: if a character holds a coffee cup, check it exists in every frame and doesn't change color/hand.
- **R-114** For slow motion, describe the event at normal speed and add "slow motion" style treatment; models handle the retiming cue.
- **R-115** Loops: if you want a seamless loop, describe the final state as identical to the initial state and use first/last-frame matching where the model supports it.

10. Style & Genre Treatment (RULE)

- **R-116** Set overall visual style FIRST in the prompt, then shot details — style established early governs everything after (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-117** Use film-stock and era language for live-action looks: "1970s 35mm film", "16mm black-and-white", "IMAX-scale epic", "super 8 home video" (OpenAI Sora 2 guide examples).
- **R-118** Use animation-medium language for stylized looks: "3D animated feature style", "hand-drawn cel animation", "stop-motion felt puppets", "paper cut-out animation" (Google Veo docs list animation styles).
- **R-119** Skip quality slogans — "masterpiece", "8K", "best quality" do not specify content and do not set output resolution (production guide, image prompts).
- **R-120** Name a reference look precisely: "shot like a nature documentary" is a style instruction that changes camera behavior, not just color.
- **R-121** Genre carries camera rules: horror = slow reveals and negative space; comedy = wider framing and timing; documentary = handheld and observational.

- **R-122** Avoid stacking contradictory styles ("photorealistic anime") — pick one dominant register per project.
- **R-123** Texture words carry style: "grainy", "glossy", "matte", "weathered", "pristine" — surfaces communicate style more than adjectives like "beautiful".
- **R-124** Consistency beats novelty: a coherent single style across all clips outperforms a mix of impressive looks.
- **R-125** For brand work, style derives from the brand's visual system (colors, tone, typography feel) — never impose an unrelated cinematic style on an explicit brief (production guide).

11. Universal Prompt Architecture (RULE)

- **R-126** The master shot-prompt order: **Objective/shot intent → Subject + references → Action beats → Setting → Framing + camera movement → Lighting + visual treatment → Timing → Audio/dialogue → Continuity constraints.** (Advisor-endorsed structure.)
- **R-127** Write the prompt as a creative brief for a cinematographer who has not seen your storyboard — missing details leave the model room to improvise (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-128** A prompt is a wish list, not a contract: more detail = more control and consistency; less detail = more variation. Choose per shot (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-129** Order the prompt so the most important elements come first — widely recommended practitioner guidance (fal.ai Sora 2 Pro tips); treat it as a working convention rather than a verified mechanism.
- **R-130** Keep prompts specific but not overloaded — over-stuffed prompts with too many simultaneous actions degrade all of them (theprotec.com Veo/Kling prompting analysis).
- **R-131** Separate concerns structurally where the model supports it: prose scene description, then a "Cinematography:" block, then "Actions:", then "Dialogue:" (OpenAI Sora 2 template).
- **R-132** Keep prose and parameters separate: resolution, duration, aspect ratio, and references are API/tool parameters — writing them in prose does not enforce them (OpenAI Sora 2 guide; media skill).
- **R-133** Specify what the viewer notices first in the frame — it's a priority instruction for attention.
- **R-134** For multi-shot prompts (where supported), keep each shot block distinct with one camera setup, one subject action, one lighting recipe per block (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-135** Write for the model you use. Practitioner-reported prompt-shape preferences (Runway concise; Veo/Sora structured detail; Kling subject + movement + style — invideo and mstudio comparisons) are starting points to verify against your own results, not guaranteed rules.
- **R-136** Iterate in small steps: small changes to camera, lighting, or action change the result substantially — change one variable per retry so you learn what worked (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).

- **R-137** Same prompt, different results: regeneration is a feature. Use takes, don't fight variance; keep the best take and log it.
- **R-138** Keep a prompt log per clip: prompt text, model, parameters, seed/take, verdict. Prompt logs turn failures into team learning.
- **R-139** When a prompt fails twice, rewrite it — don't rerun it a third time hoping (production-guide economics; iteration budget L-17).
- **R-140** The strongest failure-recovery pattern: simplify. Cut to one action, one move, one light source, regenerate, then re-add detail.

12. Image-to-Video Workflows (COND)

- **R-141** Image-to-video is the default path for controlled shots: the keyframe sets subject, framing, and style; the prompt only adds motion (production guide).
- **R-142** For image-to-video, describe ONLY motion and changes — don't re-describe the image. Redescribing its contents can reduce motion or produce unexpected results (production guide).
- **R-143** A strong keyframe with a weak video prompt produces static, lifeless output — the video prompt must carry the motion (production guide).
- **R-144** Separate vendor capability from your actual route. Vendor API: Veo 3.1 accepts up to three reference images for subject consistency (Google Veo docs, verified Oct 2026). This team's tool route: a single starting image, and if several are supplied only the last is used (media skill). Always check the route you are actually calling — a vendor feature is not available through every integration.
- **R-145** State each reference image's role by position ("image 1 is the product, image 2 is the lighting reference") where multi-reference is supported (media skill, images).
- **R-146** First/last-frame control is a vendor API capability (Veo 3.1 `image` + `lastFrame`, Google Veo docs, verified Oct 2026): defining both frames gives strong shot-composition control as the model interpolates between them. This team's tool route does not expose `lastFrame` — verify your interface before promising this control.
- **R-147** Choose the starting image closest to the desired FIRST scene — the model animates from it (Google Veo docs).
- **R-148** User photos that aren't cinematic can be transformed first: `generate_image` with the photo as reference to create a clean video starting frame, then animate (production guide, image transformation).
- **R-149** If a scene needs more references than the model accepts, combine them into a single keyframe first, then animate that keyframe (production guide).
- **R-150** Aspect ratio of the keyframe must match the target video; prepare crops or letterboxing before animation when exact proportions matter (production guide).
- **R-151** Frame-chaining procedure: generate clip → extract last frame (`ffmpeg -sseof -0.1 -i clip.mp4 -frames:v 1 -q:v 2 last-frame.jpg`) → feed as the next starting image with a continuation prompt describing how the scene continues (production guide).

- **R-152** Write continuation prompts naturally: clip 1 "a woman walking through a forest" → clip 2 "she reaches a clearing and looks up at the sky" (production guide).
- **R-153** Inspect every join for identity, lighting, and motion continuity; a matching boundary frame does not guarantee a continuous-looking shot (production guide).
- **R-154** Frame-chaining suits continuous motion, ambient shots, gradual transitions, establishing shots — not distinct story beats (production guide).
- **R-155** Video extension (where supported, e.g., Veo 3.1 extend): the process finalizes the last second (24 frames) and continues action; the voice must be present in the last 1 second to be extended with audio (Google Veo docs).

13. Model-Specific Rules (COND)

Model rules change as models change — verify against current official docs before a new project. These reflect current-generation behavior.

13.1 Veo (Google)

- **R-156** Veo prompt elements: subject, action, style, camera positioning/motion, composition, focus/lens effects, ambiance — Google's own recommended checklist (Google Veo docs).
- **R-157** Veo dialogue: put exact speech in quotation marks and attribute it — `"This must be the key," he murmured` (Google Veo docs).
- **R-158** Veo sound effects: describe sounds explicitly — "tires screeching loudly, engine roaring" (Google Veo docs).
- **R-159** Veo ambience: describe the environment's soundscape — "a faint, eerie hum resonates in the background" (Google Veo docs).
- **R-160** Veo can hallucinate unwanted audio (e.g., audience laughter) when ambient sound is undefined — always define the soundscape (production guide).
- **R-161** Veo native audio is not guaranteed: check lip sync, word accuracy, timing, and that silence is actually silent (media skill).
- **R-162** Veo safety blocks: generation may be blocked by safety filters; blocked generations are not charged (Google Veo docs).
- **R-163** Veo starting from an image does not guarantee faces, text, or lighting stay unchanged — inspect through the entire clip (media skill).
- **R-164** Veo image-to-video suits animating objects, drawings, paintings, and adding movement/sound to nature scenes (Google Veo docs).

13.2 Sora (OpenAI)

- **R-165** Sora follows instructions more reliably in shorter clips — prefer 4–8s shots and stitch (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-166** Sora dialogue timing: a 4-second shot fits one or two short exchanges; long complex speeches break sync and pacing (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-167** Sora color anchors: name 3–5 colors to stabilize palette across shots (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-168** Sora character continuity: keep descriptions consistent, reuse phrasing, don't mix competing traits (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-169** Sora shot blocks: one camera setup, one action, one lighting recipe per block; multiple blocks per prompt are valid (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-170** Sora extensions: up to 20s per extension, up to six extensions, 120s total per video (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-171** Sora parameters (seconds: 4/8/12/16/20, resolution, references) are API settings, not prose (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).

13.3 Seedance / MiniMax / others

- **R-172** Seedance 2.0: 720p default (1080p costs more), fixed 16:9, durations 4/6/8/12s, one starting image (last supplied wins), `audio: false` not honored — strip audio in post if silence is needed (media skill).
- **R-173** Seedance 2.5: up to 30s duration and up to 30 reference images, honors aspect ratio and audio settings; costs more than 2.0 and is not a guaranteed quality upgrade (media skill).
- **R-174** MiniMax H3: up to 2K output, opening image or opening/final pair; image-to-video inherits the opening image's aspect ratio; native audio always generated and cannot be disabled (media skill).
- **R-175** Every model has different prompt-shape preferences (Runway concise; Kling subject+motion+style; Veo/Sora structured detail) — adapt prompt shape per model, don't reuse one prompt verbatim across models (invideo/mstudio comparisons).
- **R-176** Duration and reference-image limits differ per model and per tool wrapper — check the tool's current docs, not vendor marketing pages (media skill warning).

14. Audio, Dialogue & Voice (RULE)

- **R-177** Decide the audio strategy per project: native model audio, TTS voiceover, or both layered (production guide).
- **R-178** Native video audio strategy: describe dialogue, sound effects, and ambience in the prompt and verify the result (production guide).
- **R-179** TTS strategy: use when you need specific voice character, precise emotional delivery, or two-voice dialogue (production guide).

- **R-180** Combined strategy: generate video with native ambient audio, layer TTS voiceover on top — environmental realism plus precise voice control (production guide).
- **R-181** TTS and video durations never match exactly. This is a narration-calibration rule, not a universal editing law — normal editorial trimming for pacing (R-204) is expected; what is forbidden is stretching, speeding, or trimming a track specifically to force a narration/video duration match. Calibrate instead (production guide):
  - Narration-first: generate voiceover, measure with `ffprobe`, plan clips to cover that duration.
  - Video-first: adjust script length to fit the video.
  - Video too short: frame-chain another clip to cover the gap.
  - Audio too long: shorten the script and regenerate.
- **R-182** Aim for video slightly longer than voiceover so the tail has ambient audio, not silence; mix with `duration=longest` (production guide).
- **R-183** Voiceover mixing pattern: `ffmpeg -i video.mp4 -i voiceover.mp3 -filter_complex "[0:a]volume=0.3[bg];[1:a]volume=1.0[vo];[bg][vo]amix=inputs=2:duration=longest" -c:v copy output.mp4` (production guide).
- **R-184** Silent video delivery: `audio: false` lowers cost on Veo; on models that ignore it, strip the track after generation — this does not reduce cost (media skill).
- **R-185** Always specify the soundscape even for "quiet" scenes: "quiet room tone with a ticking clock" — undefined audio invites hallucinated sounds (production guide).
- **R-186** Diegetic-only audio is a valid instruction: "diegetic sound only, no score, no added foley" (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-187** A small sound can pace a silent shot — "distant traffic hiss", "a crisp snap" — treat it as a rhythm cue (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-188** Music: models can generate ambient score but not a specific licensed song — licensed tracks are added in post; never let a model "approximate" a known song.
- **R-189** Dialogue clips: keep speaker labels consistent and turns alternating so lines bind to the right character's gestures (OpenAI Sora 2 guide).
- **R-190** Check lip sync on every dialogue clip before locking it (media skill).
- **R-191** Audio loudness: normalize to platform standards in the final export. -14 LUFS is a common streaming/social starting target, not a verified universal — check the current spec for each delivery platform.
- **R-192** Audio continuity across cuts: ambience should flow across the cut even when the picture changes — design sound to smooth the edit.

15. Negative Prompts & Artifact Control (COND)

- **R-193** Negative prompts suppress four families of problems: quality artifacts (blur, flicker), unwanted styles, unwanted objects, and unwanted camera behavior (invideo negative-prompt guidance).
- **R-194** Use negative prompts where the model supports them; where it doesn't, convert the negative into a positive instruction ("clean single face" instead of "no extra faces").
- **R-195** The recurring artifact list to check on EVERY clip review: morphing faces, extra/missing limbs, melting hands, warped text, flicker, ghosting, duplicated people, object pass-through, identity drift, subtitle hallucination, unintended camera shake.
- **R-196** Curated negative-prompt starters (adapt per model): "text, subtitles, watermark, logo, distorted hands, extra limbs, deformed face, morphing, flickering, blurry, low quality, jittery motion, duplicated subject" (geratools/LTX negative-prompt guides).
- **R-197** Negative prompts cut failure modes before the first render — use them proactively, not reactively (LTX Studio guidance).
- **R-198** Don't over-stuff negative prompts: excessive exclusions can conflict and degrade the positive content. Keep negatives targeted at observed failures.
- **R-199** Log which negative terms actually fixed which artifact — negative vocabulary is team knowledge.
- **R-200** Some artifacts are better fixed by prompt surgery than negatives: flicker often comes from conflicting motion instructions — simplify the motion instead of banning "flicker".

16. Editing, Pacing & Post-Production (RULE)

- **R-201** The edit is where AI video is actually made. Expect to cut 2–3× more footage than you use.
- **R-202** Hard cuts are the default transition; dissolves and wipes are deliberate emotional choices, not defaults (production guide stitching).
- **R-203** Pacing starting heuristics (adapt to your footage, don't apply blindly): social cuts every 1–3s; explainer every 3–6s; cinematic sequences 6–12s. Cut on action — the movement carries the eye across the cut.
- **R-204** Trim AI clips at the start and end: the first and last ~0.5s of a generated clip are the most artifact-prone.
- **R-205** Never use a shot you haven't reviewed frame-by-frame at least once at speed. Artifacts hide in single frames.
- **R-206** J-cut/L-cut audio (audio leading or lagging the picture) smooths every dialogue edit.
- **R-207** Add all text, titles, captions, and logos in post — model-rendered text misspells and cannot be revised (L-13).
- **R-208** Color-match clips in post: even with locked palettes, per-clip color drifts; a light grade pass unifies the piece.

- **R-209** Stabilization: if a clip's motion is jittery, prefer re-generation with simpler camera moves over electronic stabilization, which smears AI footage.
- **R-210** Export standards: H.264/H.265 MP4, high bitrate, platform-native resolution; keep the master in the highest quality available.
- **R-211** Stitching command pattern for hard cuts: concatenate clips with re-encoding only when parameters differ; keep a consistent export preset across the project (production guide).
- **R-212** Always watch the FULL final export end-to-end before delivery. Every time. No exceptions.
- **R-213** Keep outtakes and takes archived with verdicts — an earlier "failed" take often becomes the fix for a later edit problem.

17. Typography, Graphics & On-Screen Text (RULE)

- **R-214** All typography is a post-production layer, never model-generated (L-13 restated as a hard rule).
- **R-215** Text-safe zones: social platforms overlay UI (top, right edge, bottom) — a starting heuristic is keeping titles inside the central 80% for 9:16; verify against the current platform UI.
- **R-216** One type family per video, maximum two weights. Hierarchy through size, not fonts.
- **R-217** Caption every spoken word for social — feed video is very frequently watched muted (a long-standing industry claim; verify the current figure for your platform rather than quoting a number).
- **R-218** Captions: high-contrast, 2–4 words on screen at a time, synced to speech rhythm, not sentence blocks.
- **R-219** Motion graphics in post should match the video's locked palette and motion energy.
- **R-220** Lower-thirds and labels: consistent position and timing rules across the whole piece — viewers learn your layout; don't move it.
- **R-221** Verify the spelling of every rendered word before delivery — quoted words must be checked (media skill, images).
- **R-222** Numbers and stats on screen: display the exact verified figure; re-check against the source log after any edit.

18. Genre Playbooks (COND)

18.1 Product / E-commerce

- **R-223** Product identity is sacred: use the actual product photo as reference; never let the model redesign the product.
- **R-224** Product shots: clean background, controlled lighting, orbit/parallax moves, macro texture moments.

- **R-225** Show the product in use by a person, not just on a pedestal — use-case shots convert.
- **R-226** Never let the model invent product features, labels, or UI that don't exist — verify every visible claim (R-05).
- **R-227** For apps/sites/documents, use real screenshots stitched with ffmpeg instead of generated fake screens (media skill).

18.2 Explainer / Educational

- **R-228** Script first, narration-first workflow: measure the VO, then plan clips to cover it (R-26).
- **R-229** One concept per scene; visual metaphors beat abstract b-roll.
- **R-230** Repeat the key point visually in at least two different ways — redundancy is a teaching tool.
- **R-231** Pacing: visual change every 3–6s; never let a static visual run under continuing narration for more than ~6s.
- **R-232** Chapter long content into ~5-minute complete units (R-23).

18.3 Documentary / Interview

- **R-233** Do not fabricate documentary footage of real events — use archival material or clearly-labeled recreation.
- **R-234** No synthetic likenesses of real people without consent — real-person rules apply to faces and voices (media skill trust boundaries).
- **R-235** Label AI-generated imagery in news-adjacent content; disclosure is an ethical and increasingly legal requirement.

18.4 Social / Shorts / Reels

- **R-236** 9:16, hook in the first 3 seconds, single message, 15–45s sweet spot.
- **R-237** Design for sound-off: captions always; but also mix so it works with sound on.
- **R-238** Front-load visual energy; apply the R-14 retention heuristic to every shot in the edit.

18.5 Animation / Stylized

- **R-239** Lock the animation medium and never mix media within a scene (L-05).
- **R-240** Stylized faces deform less than photoreal faces — but verify limb count in fast action anyway.
- **R-241** Animation style terms that work: "3D animated feature", "hand-drawn cel", "stop-motion felt puppets", "paper cut-out animation", "claymation" (Google Veo docs; production guide).

18.6 Corporate / Brand

- **R-242** Brand kit is the lock sheet (L-14): colors, fonts, logo rules, mandatory legal lines.
- **R-243** Tone: gimbal-smooth camera, soft wrap lighting, diverse and respectful representation.
- **R-244** Every claim in a corporate video is a compliance risk — legal/claims review before storyboard (R-07 analog).

18.7 Music video / Montage

- **R-245** Non-narrated content can be planned loosely, but still needs enough unique keyframes to avoid repetition (production guide).
- **R-246** Cut to the beat: mark beats in the track before final edit; AI clips are trimmed to rhythm, not the other way around.
- **R-247** Visual variety across the same track: rotate subjects/locations/color treatments per section.

18.8 Live-action drama / Narrative

- **R-248** Dialogue clips are the hardest generations — shortest lines, eye-level static camera, verify lip sync every time (R-17, R-190).
- **R-249** Shoot narrative in shot/reverse-shot pairs with matched eyelines (R-69).
- **R-250** Emotional continuity matters more than action continuity — check performance, not just geometry, in reviews.

19. Delivery & Technical Specifications (RULE)

- **R-251** Deliver what was locked in L-16: master, platform exports, captions, thumbnail. No surprise deliverables, no missing ones.
- **R-252** Platform specs (verify current values at delivery time): 16:9 up to 4K for YouTube; 9:16 1080×1920 for Reels/TikTok/Shorts; H.264 MP4 with AAC audio as the universal safe format.
- **R-253** Loudness normalization: about -14 LUFS for streaming/social; check per platform (R-191).
- **R-254** File naming per L-19; final master carries project name, version, and date.
- **R-255** Archive: project folder with script, storyboard keyframes, prompt logs, source log, takes, and the final exports. Rebuildable beats reproducible.
- **R-256** Verify the exported file plays end-to-end after every export (R-212 analog for files).
- **R-257** Thumbnails: one image that states the video's promise; faces and contrast win feeds; text minimal and verified.

20. Accessibility & Localization (RULE)

- **R-258** Captions are mandatory, not optional (R-217) — they serve deaf and hard-of-hearing viewers and muted-feed viewers alike.
- **R-259** Provide alt text/description for the video where the platform supports it.
- **R-260** Don't rely on color alone to convey meaning; add labels or icons.
- **R-261** Flashing/strobing content: avoid rapid flicker entirely — photosensitivity risk and a hard fail on many platforms.
- **R-262** Localization: re-generate narration per language (TTS voices differ), keep shot prompts unchanged, budget for re-timing captions.
- **R-263** Reading speed for on-screen text: ≥ 1.5s for a short line; don't flash text faster than speech.

21. Rights, Consent & Safety (RULE)

- **R-264** Real people: never place a real person (celebrity, public figure, private individual) in a deceptive, embarrassing, intoxicated, sexual, criminal-suggestive, in-distress, fake political, fake medical, or evidentiary context, or imply they did, said, or experienced something they did not. Editorial illustration and satire of public figures are allowed only when clearly non-photoreal, visibly labeled, and unable to pass as a real photograph. Never alter identity attributes, body shape, disability status, or likeness unless benign, consented, and non-deceptive. Paparazzi, candid, or surveillance looks require a benign authorized use (trust-boundaries policy).
- **R-265** Minors: never generate sexualized imagery or realistic/evidence-like depictions of minors involving violence, crime, intoxication, clinical treatment, weapon handling, or commercial endorsement. Clearly non-realistic, benign storybook/fairytale/play illustration is allowed. If age is uncertain, treat as a minor (trust-boundaries policy).
- **R-266** Evidence-like imagery: same rule as R-08 — no fabricated material presented as authentic evidence; clearly labeled, stylized, illustrative versions are permitted only when they cannot function as real-world evidence.
- **R-267** Third-party brands and characters: no logos, packaging, mascots, trade dress, endorsement framing, or co-branded lockups unless the user supplies assets and confirms authorization — otherwise use generic, fictional, or user-owned branding. Never depict named copyrighted characters or mascots; convert to non-infringing visual attributes (trust-boundaries policy).
- **R-268** Disclosure: label AI-generated content where required by platform or law; the trend is mandatory labeling and it protects the team.
- **R-269** Voice cloning of real people requires consent — use licensed or synthetic voices by default.
- **R-270** Music: licensed or generated; never "sounds like [famous song]" — close-copy is still infringement risk.
- **R-271** Archive consent records and licenses with the project files (R-255).

22. Agent Team Operations & QA Gates (RULE)

- **R-272** Roles: Script Agent (owns Sections 2–3), Storyboard Agent (4–5), Generation Agent (6–13), Audio Agent (14), Editorial Agent (16–17), QA Agent (all sections), Team Head (locks and sign-offs).
- **R-273** Handoffs carry the lock sheet, the current section's rules, and the prompt log — an agent without the lock sheet is a rogue agent.
- **R-274** The QA gate checklist per clip: identity/continuity ✓, anatomy artifacts ✓, text spelling ✓, lip sync ✓, lighting consistency ✓, motion as prompted ✓, audio as prompted ✓, duration ✓, aspect ratio ✓.
- **R-275** The QA gate checklist per project: brief match ✓, all claims sourced ✓, captions ✓, loudness ✓, deliverables complete ✓, export verified ✓.
- **R-276** Locked means locked: a clip passing QA is archived and never regenerated unless a downstream failure demands it — and that decision is logged.
- **R-277** Cost discipline: video is billed per second; confirm before generating more than one clip per request, and put the cost in the confirmation (media skill).
- **R-278** One video generation per request unless more are explicitly approved (media skill).
- **R-279** If generation fails or times out, check for the output file before retrying; if sharing fails, share the returned path rather than regenerating (media skill).
- **R-280** Version everything: script, storyboard, prompts, cuts. "Final_v2_REAL_final" is a process failure; dates and versions are mandatory (L-19).
- **R-281** Escalation path: two failed regenerations → simplify the prompt (R-140); three failures → escalate to team head with the prompt log.
- **R-282** Post-mortem every project: what artifacts appeared, which prompts fixed them, which rules need amendment. Feed learnings back into this rulebook.
- **R-283** This rulebook is versioned; rule changes are logged with date and rationale. Rules are amended, never silently deleted.

23. Templates

23.1 Master shot-prompt template

```
[SHOT INTENT: what this clip is for, in one line]

Subject: [who/what, with 2-4 durable identity anchors, verbatim from the character sh
Setting: [location, era, weather, set dressing that matters]
Action: [2-3 sequential beats with counts and end-state]
Camera: [framing] + [angle] + [one movement, with speed adjective]
Lighting: [direction] + [quality] + [time of day] + [color anchors from lock sheet]
Style: [locked medium/style from lock sheet]
Timing: [duration class; slow/normal/fast internal pacing]
```

```
Audio: [ambience + sound effects + dialogue in quotes, or "ambient only"]
Continuity: [what must match the previous clip: wardrobe, screen direction, light di
```

23.2 Sora-style structured template (OpenAI Sora 2 guide)

```
[Prose scene description: characters, costumes, scenery, weather.]

Cinematography:
Camera shot: [framing and angle]
Mood: [tone]

Actions:
- [Beat 1]
- [Beat 2]
- [Dialogue line if present]

Dialogue:
Speaker: "Exact line."
```

23.3 Project lock sheet (fill once)

```
Purpose:            One sentence
Audience:           Who / knowledge level / desired action
Platform & ratio:   e.g., YouTube 16:9
Duration class:     e.g., 3-min explainer
Medium/style:       e.g., photorealistic documentary
Color anchors:      3-5 named colors
Lighting style:     e.g., soft natural, golden hour
Camera personality: e.g., gimbal-smooth
Narration:          voice / language / accent
Audio strategy:      native / TTS / layered
Model set:           primary / fallback
Text policy:        all in post
Brand elements:      logo, colors, fonts, legal
Safety boundaries:  no real likenesses, no minors, no fake evidence
Deliverables:       master, exports, captions, thumbnail
Iteration budget:   max takes per clip
Review gate:        who signs off
File naming:        project/scene/shot/take
Definition of done: platform-uploaded, captioned, archived
```

23.4 Agent handoff checklist

```
[ ] Lock sheet attached and current
[ ] Script version referenced
[ ] Shot list with IDs and durations
[ ] Reference images attached (characters/product/locations)
[ ] Prompt log updated with last take + verdict
[ ] QA checklist results for completed clips
[ ] Open issues and blocked rules noted
```

24. Sources

- Google — Generate videos with Veo 3.1 (Gemini API docs)
- OpenAI — Sora 2 Prompting Guide (Cookbook)
- OpenAI — Video generation with Sora (API guide)
- Google — Prompt design strategies (Gemini API)
- invideo — How to write AI video prompts for Runway, Kling, Sora, and Veo
- invideo — Cinematography terms for AI video prompts
- invideo — What to put in a negative prompt for AI video
- mstudio — How to prompt AI video models: Kling, Veo, Runway, Wan, Seedance
- LTX — Negative prompts guide
- Gera Tools — Video generation negative prompt guide
- fal.ai — How to make videos on Sora 2 Pro
- The Protec — AI video prompts for cinematic clips (Veo, Runway, Kling)
- Internal: media skill production guide and model documentation (`skills/media/video-production/GUIDE.md`, `skills/media/models/video-models.md`) — platform-locked operational rules for the generation toolchain used by this team.

25. Program Roadmap to 10,000 Points

- **Part 1 (this document):** 303 numbered entries (20 locks + 283 rules) across the full production lifecycle — the foundational operating baseline, not the complete standard.
- **Part 2 (next):** Genre deep-dives — 20+ genres × ~100 rules each (product, education, documentary, news, drama, comedy, gaming, real estate, fitness, food, fashion, automotive, SaaS demo, event, nonprofit, recruitment, training, tourism, sports, music, kids' content with safety rules).
- **Part 3:** Per-model prompt libraries — curated, tested prompt patterns and negative-prompt sets per model and per shot type.
- **Part 4:** Shot-recipe matrices — camera × lighting × subject-type × genre combinations with verified prompt fragments.
- **Part 5:** Failure-mode encyclopedia — every known artifact, its cause, its fix, and its prevention rule.
- Say "continue the program" and I will build the next part.